



As a result, the proportion of women independent directors has risen from 3.23% in 2013 to 27.75% in 2024



But the limited senior roles offered to women highlights the prevalent gender disparities in India

regulatory measures like the Companies Act aim to prevent that by capping the number of positions—an individual can be on the boards of 10 listed companies and 20 overall. This highlights the limited pool from which women directors are often selected, perpetuating a cycle where the same individuals serve on multiple boards.

One justification often given for this phenomenon is that there aren't enough qualified women available. Yet, Primeinfobase data reveals that women directors are highly educated with 6% having doctorates, 54% holding master's degrees, and 23% holding bachelor's degrees as their highest qualification. "The quality of women independent directors appointed to Indian boards is, by and large, commendable. Many of these individuals bring a wealth of experience in law, finance, strategy, and corporate governance," says Tushar Kumar, an advocate at the Supreme Court of India.

However, Kumar acknowledges that the relatively small pool of women with executive or board-level experience, particularly in sectors traditionally dominated by men, poses a challenge. "To address this, there has been a concerted effort to expand training and development programmes aimed at preparing women for these roles, ensuring that they possess both the requisite expertise and the ability to contribute meaningfully to governance."

THE PATH FORWARD

To improve gender diversity in boardrooms, boards must stop seeing it as simply meeting quotas. It involves addressing deeper cultural and structural barriers. Being a woman director often means navigating male-dominated boardrooms, dealing with higher scrutiny, and managing multiple roles. Krishan Mishra, CEO of financial planning body, FPSB India says, "Challenges often include overcoming bi-

ases in a male dominated fields and balancing responsibilities with societal expectations. The number of women on boards continues to be low due to a bleak talent pipeline at the mid-level, systemic hurdles, and traditional mindsets."

Mishra adds that we must work towards creating a supportive work environment. Businesses must prioritise diversity, nurture leadership pipelines, and provide mentorship opportunities.

Access to influential networks and leadership development opportunities is often restricted for women, with many companies failing to actively groom women for top roles. Moreover, tokenism remains a concern, as some companies appoint women to meet legal requirements rather than for their expertise.

To foster meaningful change, companies must adopt a holistic approach towards diversity. This involves rethinking recruitment strategies, implementing flexible work policies, and establishing mentorship programmes that encourage women to pursue leadership roles. "Diversity at the board level is imperative for an inclusive organisation since such values are always top-down. The mandate for one woman independent director has certainly led to a significant increase in the number of women on boards," says Anchal Dhir, Partner at law firm Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

Some organisations—such as AstraZeneca, Cummins India, Apollo Hospitals, and Godrej Agrovet—have taken the lead in ensuring better representation by appointing six or more women to their boards. "A valuable lesson I learnt from my father, Dr Prathap C. Reddy, was that a problem remains one only if you choose to view it that way. However, if you eliminate the mental barriers that convince you something is impossible, remarkable progress can be made," says Preetha Reddy, Executive Vice Chairperson of Apollo Hospitals Enterprise.



"We must work towards creating an environment that allows women to be on boards of companies and harness their potential"

Krishan Mishra
CEO, FPSB INDIA